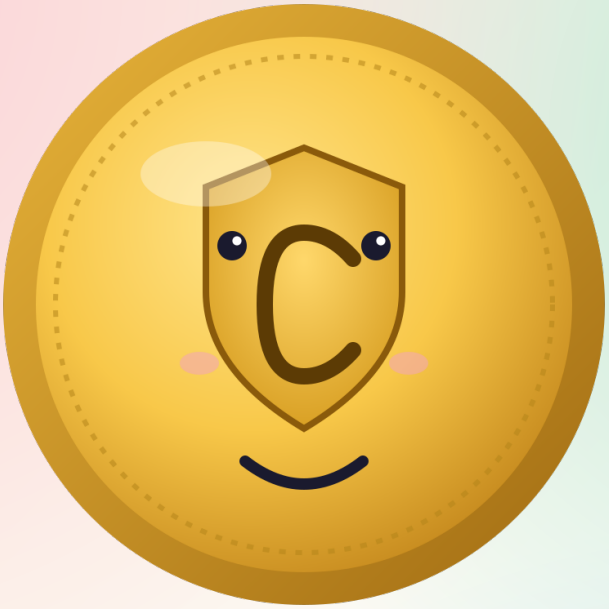


GRADE 1

Teacher Guide

C A S H

Businesses make things or do things.

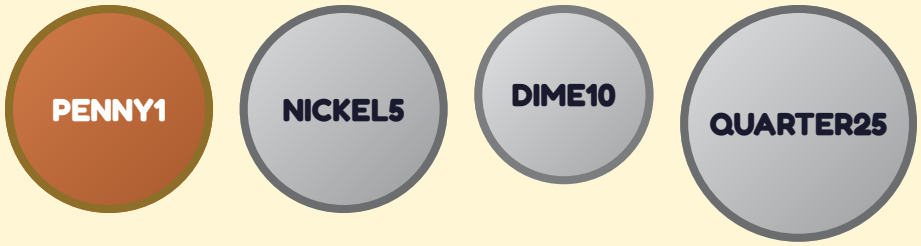
Routines, pacing, and the small moves that work.

Grade 1 — Cash to Company: Teacher Guide

For: first-grade classroom teachers, homeschool parents teaching the curriculum, after-school program leads, paraprofessionals supporting Grade 1 classrooms. **Companion to:** Grade 1 Curriculum Book, Lesson Plans, Student Activity Book, Cash Video Scripts, and Parent Guide.

How this year is built (and why)

Grade 1 of Cash to Company is built around two moves: **sorting** (make a thing or do a thing?) and **counting** (coins on the mat, up to 50¢). Both are concrete. Both are within reach of a six-year-old. Both feed directly into Grade 2 (problem-solving) and Grade 3 (cost, revenue, profit).



We do not teach money in any complicated way this year. We teach coins. There is a difference. Money is an abstraction; a six-year-old still cannot meaningfully hold "money" in their head. Coins they can hold in their hand and add. We name four coins (review from K), put them on a mat, and add up to 50¢. That is the whole financial spine.

The "make or do" sort is original and intentional. Most early-childhood materials skip from "businesses help people" (K) to "businesses solve problems" (Grade 2). The leap is too long for a six-year-old still building category language. The sort is the bridge.

The pedagogical bones come from three traditions that fit early childhood:

- **Play-based learning.** Most of the work of Grade 1 is dramatic play. The Classroom Store is the year's centerpiece because children learn the social and operational moves of business through pretend before they could ever learn them through worksheets.
- **Routines, not heroics.** A predictable rhythm — a daily make or do? opener, a Tuesday/Thursday Word Wall touch, a coin-counting moment, twice-weekly Classroom Store rotations in Unit 4 — is more powerful than any single brilliant lesson.
- **Picture-first.** Every page in the program's K-2 materials is at least 60% illustration. We assume children are reading-emergent, not reading-fluent. The pictures are the lesson.

Classroom routines (the year, on autopilot)

Set these in the first three weeks. Protect them.

The "Make or do?" opener (every Cash to Company block)

At the start of every block, hold up a business card and ask: "make or do?" Take 3–5 calls. By Week 6, children will start saying the answer before you finish the question.

The Word Wall touch (Tuesdays and Thursdays, 3 minutes)

Point at one word on the wall. Say it. Children echo. Point at one more. Say it. Children echo. Done. Three minutes.

The Make/Do Sort Wall add (one per week)

Pick one child each week to add a new business square. Rotate so every child gets a turn over the year. The Sort Wall fills slowly — that's fine.

The coin moment (every block during Unit 2)

Place three coin cards on the rug. "Count this mat. How much?" Children call out. Three coins, then done. Three minutes.

The Classroom Store (twice a week during Unit 4)

Three groups of three children rotate through. Two cycles per session, 15 minutes total. The rest of the class watches and cheers softly.

Pedagogy at this grade band

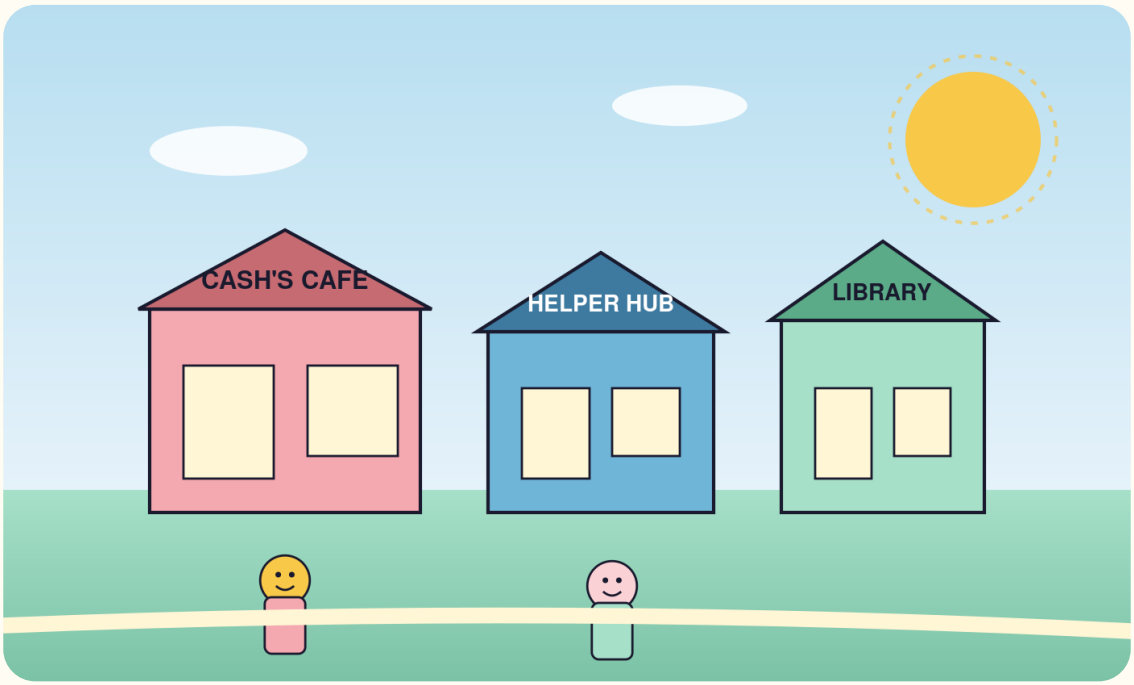
- **Concrete only.** A real coin in a hand beats the word money on a page. Real photos of bakeries beat abstract drawings. Real bread on a counter beats the idea of bread. The 30-cent ice pop card on a desk beats the abstract notion of a price.
- **Repetition is friendly.** First graders thrive on repeated phrases. "Make or do? Look. Look. Look." The teacher says it. The children echo. By Week 12, children say it on their own.
- **Talk, then draw, then sometimes write.** Most first graders are mid-emergent writers. Talking is the assessment. Drawing is the artifact. Writing is teacher-supported (the teacher captures the child's words on the bottom

of the page in adult handwriting if needed). By June, many children will write a full word or two on their own — receive that as a bonus, not the standard.

- **Identity-aware.** Many of the businesses children name will be ones their family runs or works at. Receive every answer warmly. Avoid corrections that imply a child's family business is "wrong" — instead, sort it together. "Your dad's tow truck — make or do?" (Do.) "Your auntie's bakery — make or do?" (Make.)
- **Movement-based.** Most lessons include children moving — to the rug, to the wall, to the store corner. Wiggly is the default at this age. Plan for it.
- **Not a worksheet curriculum.** The Activity Book is mostly drawing, circling, and coin counting. If a teacher finds themselves printing extra worksheets, something has shifted away from the spine. The dramatic play, the Sort Wall, and the coin routine are the lesson.

CASH SAYS

Which coin is more? Show me with your hands.



Helpers are everywhere. Each one is a kind of business.

Assessment philosophy

Assessment in Grade 1 is **observation-based**, not written. The class checklist (one page) is the year's gradebook.

We watch for two things:

1. **Did the child do the move the standard names?** Did they actually sort a card MAKE or DO? Did they actually count a 3-coin mat to 35¢?

2. **Can they tell a grown-up what they did?** Oral report is the K-2 version of "explanation." A child who can say "first I picked the strip, next I drew, next I wrote my name, last I tied the yarn" has the OSO standard.

We do not grade neatness. We do not grade spelling — most first graders cannot spell yet. We do not assign letter grades or numbers. The checklist is Y / N. By June, most children should have most boxes checked. If a box is empty for many children, we re-teach.

A typical assessment cadence

Cadence	Form	Stakes
Daily	Visible-thinking note (the sort a child volunteered, the kind word a child used)	None — formative observation
Weekly	Sort Wall contribution; coin mat count; Classroom Store role-play	None — observation only
End of unit	Class checklist update + capstone artifact (Sort Wall card, Coin Mat Booklet, Recipe Card, Sign)	Low — for teacher's planning and family conference
End of year	Family Visit Day (the showcase)	The year's culmination — observation only

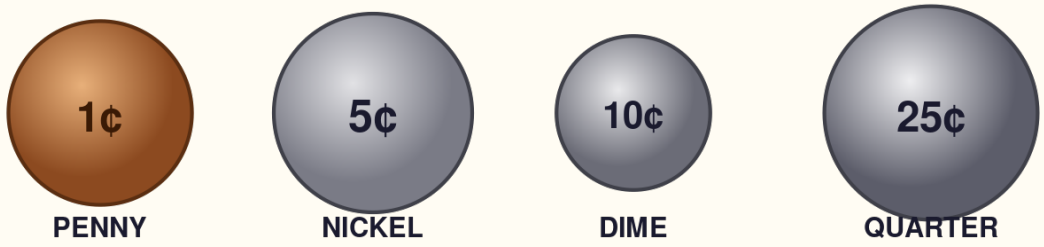
Working with emergent readers and writers

- **Read every word out loud.** The Activity Book is designed to be read by the teacher (or family adult) to the child. Do not assume the child can read the prompts.

- **Picture cards beat text cards.** When sorting, matching, or sequencing, use cards with pictures, not words. (Words can sit alongside the picture as exposure.)
- **Sentence frames are spoken, not always written.** "Please, may I have a ___?" Children rehearse out loud. Sentence-frame cards held up are fine; reading them is bonus.
- **Captions written by the teacher when needed.** When a child draws a business, ask, "who is this?" Write the child's words in adult handwriting at the bottom. By Week 18, most first graders will write the name themselves; let them.
- **The Word Wall is a touch-and-say wall, not a read-fluently wall.** Children point and say. Reading the words alone develops over the year — by June, most will read the wall.

Dramatic play setup (the most important environment in the room)

The Classroom Store is the centerpiece of Unit 4 and runs for nine weeks. Set it up well.



Penny. Nickel. Dime. Quarter. We say each name out loud.

The corner. Pick a corner of the classroom. Small table. Two chairs. A shelf or counter for the products and signs.

Aprons. 4–6 paper aprons (or fabric, if available). Children put one on when they take the worker role.

Pretend products. Bookmarks (children make them in Lesson 6). Felt or paper trail-mix bags. Paper lemonade cups. Paper flowers. Avoid food labeled as "junk" or "healthy" — just food. Allergies: do not use real food in the store.

Pretend coins. Use coin cards from Unit 2. Children "pay" with cards, not real coins. Real coins appear only in supervised lessons.

Signs. Hand-drawn price signs: "BOOKMARK — 10¢. TRAIL MIX — 25¢. LEMONADE — 30¢. FLOWER — 15¢." Children's individual signs (from Lesson 9) are pinned at small assigned spots.

The OPEN/CLOSED sign. Children flip the sign at the start and end of each store session. This is its own ritual; respect it.

The JOBS chart. Three roles on a small chart inside the store corner: worker, customer, sign-keeper. A clip moves to mark whose turn it is. Coach against any child "owning" a role.

Sound and tidiness. The store gets loud and silly. That is the work, within reason. The expectation: kind words at all times, hands kept to oneself, the corner stays roughly tidy. The sign-keeper handles tidiness — name them as the most important role and the children will believe you.

CASH SAYS

What comes first? What comes next?

Classroom management for 6-year-olds (specific to this curriculum)

- **A child won't take a turn at the Classroom Store.** Don't push. Watching is participation for the first 1–2 sessions. By session 3 or 4, most join. If a child never joins, partner them with a peer; the peer plays, the child holds the OPEN sign or the price sign. Mark Y on the checklist.
- **A child uses unkind words.** Pause the play. Say the rule: "At the Classroom Store, we use kind words." Have the child try again. Almost all first graders self-correct on the second try. If unkind words continue, redirect to the sign-keeper role (fewer speaking lines).
- **Two children fight over the same role.** Use the JOBS chart. Move the clip. "Right now it is Maya's turn to be the worker. Next, it is Liam's." Repeat. The chart wins more arguments than the teacher.
- **A child finishes early.** Send them to the Word Wall to point at three words and say them. Or to the Sort Wall to choose their favorite square. Or to the coin mat to count one combination. All count as on-task.
- **A child names a "business" that isn't really one.** Receive warmly. "Yes, your sister's lemonade stand is a business — she makes lemonade. Today, let's find another business outside our family." Redirect. Don't correct.
- **A whole-class meltdown on a hard day.** Skip the lesson. Read a picture book from the anchor list. Children will absorb half the standards from the read-aloud anyway.

Pacing — what to do if you're behind

If you reach Week 18 and Unit 2 isn't done, that's normal. Compress: spend Week 19 finishing coins, then start Unit 3 Week 20. The year is forgiving at

Grade 1. The Capstone (Classroom Store) is the protected territory — do not cut Unit 4 below 7 weeks.

If you reach Week 9 and the Sort Wall has only 3 squares, slow down. Skip the both puzzle for now (pizza shop, school) and just do clean MAKE and DO until Week 12. Re-introduce the fuzzy middle in Unit 1's review week.

Common pitfalls

- **Trying to teach money instead of coins.** Resist the temptation to bring in dollars, change-making from $1, or pricing strategy. Save those for Grade 2 (making change from a dollar) and Grade 3 (cost, revenue, profit). At Grade 1, counting to 50¢ is enough.
- **Asking children about real-life money.** Don't. Ever. Not even a soft version of the question. Family money is off-limits at every grade. Always frame the is it enough? question for a pretend purchase / a sample. (See Sensitivity below.)
- **Reading worksheets aloud as if children can follow.** Most can't read fluently yet. Slow down. Point at the picture. Read the prompt. Read it again.
- **Letting the Classroom Store drift.** Without the JOBS chart and the kind-words rule, the store will drift into chaos by Week 32. Reset the rules at the start of every session.
- **Skipping the Cash videos.** The videos are 1:30–2:00. They do real work. They are short on purpose. Watch them.
- **Treating the year like an academic period.** This is play, sorting, counting, and noticing. If it feels like a lecture, something has gone wrong.
- **Treating the make or do sort as a test.** It is a sorting habit, not a multiple-choice quiz. Many businesses do BOTH. The fuzzy middle is part of the lesson.

CASH SAYS

Tell me what they said with their words.

Sensitivity rules (non-negotiable)

- **Never ask about family money.** Not income. Not what a parent earns. Not whether a child has coins at home. Not what something costs in the child's home. The is it enough? question is always framed as for a sample, pretend.
- **Never ask "what does your parent do for work?"** as a survey question. If a child volunteers, receive warmly. Move on.
- **Never frame the things people in my home need done lesson as personal disclosure.** Use a pretend home. If a child volunteers a real-life detail, listen warmly, do not probe, redirect to the pretend home.
- **Never ask "has someone broken a promise to you?"** in the promises lesson. Use the story characters. If a child volunteers a personal example, listen warmly, redirect to the story.
- **Never label a food as junk or healthy.** Not even a soft version. Food is food.
- **Always check allergies** before any real food activity (e.g., trail mix). Provide a non-food alternative for any child with a restriction. The pretend version of trail mix (felt cereal, paper raisins) is the equal-status default.
- **Never single out a child for what their family does or does not do.** Receive every answer warmly. Move on.

Frequently asked questions

My class includes a wide range of readers — some are reading, some aren't. How do I run the Activity Book? Read every page aloud, every time. Strong readers won't be insulted. Struggling readers won't be left out. Many will follow along on the page.

Can I add my own businesses to the Sort Wall list? Yes. Use any businesses your community actually has — a fishmonger, a tow truck, a tailor, a bus station, a bike repair shop, a barbershop. The list in the Curriculum Book is a starting list, not a closing list.

A family asked if their child can interview them about their job for the unit. Can we? Sure. Send the child home with a picture card to draw. The grown-up tells the child what they do; the child draws it. Sort it together — make, do, or both. Add to the Sort Wall.

A child has a fine-motor delay and struggles with drawing. Provide pre-printed sticker pages. The child peels and places. The artifact is still the child's choice; the drawing skill is not the standard. Same for hole-punching during the bookmark recipe — adult-assisted is fine.

The school doesn't have real coins. Is that okay? Yes. Use coin cards for the whole year. Real coins are nice but not required. Many schools avoid them for handling reasons.

One child can already count by 5s and is bored during the coin lessons. Push them. Add the question: "how much altogether?" Two dimes and three nickels = 35. Or: "How can you make 50 cents three different ways?" Mark them as advanced on the checklist. Continue them through the regular lessons; the social work (taking turns, kind words) is for them too.

A child's recipe card has only 3 steps. Coach: "What's the very first thing? Did you forget the bowl?" Often the missing step is the setup or the cleanup. Help them add it. Four steps is the standard.

A child cannot count past 20 yet. Slow down. Use only two coins. Use the dot chart. Pair them with a peer. Mark on the checklist as needs-more-time. Re-teach in Week 18 with a small-group pull-out.

Can the Family Visit Day be virtual? Yes. A family member on video call can be the grown-up. The teacher narrates. The child holds the sign up to the camera. Counts as completed.

Cross-grade hook (what this year sets up for Grade 2)

Grade 2's theme is "Businesses solve problems." In Grade 1, students sort businesses by what they do. In Grade 2, they identify a problem and a business that already solves a problem like it.

The bridge is sturdy. A child who can say "the bakery makes bread" and "the dog walker walks dogs" is exactly ready to ask "what problem does the dog walker solve?" — answer: the family is at work. The dog needs to go out. "What problem does the bakery solve?" — answer: people want fresh bread but most don't make it themselves.

Coin work in Grade 1 (counting to 50¢ on a mat) sets up Grade 2's making change from a dollar. Recipe-card work in Grade 1 (4-step recipe) sets up Grade 2's setup checklist for a "store" station. The Classroom Store in Grade 1 sets up Grade 2's expanded class-run problem-solving stand.

A strong Grade 1 makes Grade 2 dramatically easier. Plant the routines. Trust the spine.

CASH SAYS

Notice, notice, notice. What did you see?

A note to first-time teachers of this curriculum

You do not need a business background to teach this. You need to be willing to point at a bakery and say "make" and point at a dog walker and say "do" about fifty times until the children are pointing first. Cash will do the heavy lifting on the videos. The lesson plans take the pacing decisions off your plate. Your highest-leverage move is the make or do? opener. By Week 12, your room will be a sorting room. By Week 30, the Classroom Store will run itself. That is the sound of the year working.

Calibration tip: pull one 3 — Proficient anchor for each capstone artifact (one Sort Wall card, one Coin Mat Booklet page, one Recipe Card, one Sign) and post them on a small Grade 1 Anchors corner. Look at the anchor first, then at the child's work. Anchor papers are calibration; calibration is fairness.

Senior expert upgrade pack — Differentiation deep moves (Grade 1)

Advanced learners — three named extensions

1. **Make-and-do sort.** For students who get the make-or-do sort cold, add a third box: both. "Tell me a business that does both." (A bakery: makes bread, and helps you find the right loaf.) This is the seed of value-chain reasoning at Grade 6.
2. **Sign critique.** Show two student-drawn signs. Ask the advanced learner: "Which sign tells the customer more? Why?" Push for a one-sentence reason. Builds CBM strand depth.
3. **Inventing a business.** "Imagine a helper our town doesn't have. What's their sign? What do they do?" Builds PSIG in a way Grade 2 will pick up.

ELL deep moves

- **Cognate seeds.** Spanish negocio = business. Hacer = make. Hacer shows up in many cognates.
- **Picture-first dialogue.** When asking a child to describe a helper, hand them the picture first. They point, then they speak.
- **Allow the home-language sign.** A child can write the sign in their home language plus a small drawing. Add the English version next to it.

IEP/504 deep moves

- **Counting support.** Provide a coin-value chart taped to the desk for the year. Children consult it; that's the point.
- **Sentence stems for the partner share.** "My partner did well at ___." Pre-printed on a card.

- **Movement breaks during the long classroom-store session.** Children rotate roles every 5 minutes, not every 15.

CASH

Which people, and how do you know?

ROUND 2 PATCH — Cash Never Says (Teacher Reference Card)

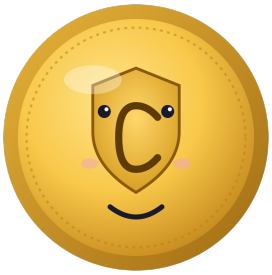
Cash to Company holds a hard line on the language we use about money, work, and ventures. The brand sets the tone; the classroom matches it. Print this on the inside cover of your Teacher Guide.

Cash never says: "Amazing!" / "Awesome!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up" / "Get that bag" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Anyone can be a millionaire" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Financial freedom" / "Just believe" / "Believe in yourself" (as a substitute for evidence) / "If you can dream it, you can do it" / "Money is fun!" (alone) / "Side hustle" (use "side venture") / wealth-flexing language / anything implying wealth is a matter of mindset or hustle / anything implying low-income or unbanked families are at fault.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "What did they actually say?" / "Whats the evidence?" / "What would have to be true for you to be right?" / "What would have to be true for you to be wrong?" / "Whats one thing youd change?"

Teacher mirror: When you praise, mirror Cashs voice. Say "okay, thats specific — whats the evidence?" instead of "great job!" Specific feedback beats enthusiasm every time.

Cashs three signature physical moves: (1) **Notebook Tilt** — turning the clipboard toward camera before reading a quote; (2) **Two-Finger Tap** — tapping a number twice when emphasizing it; (3) **Slow Lean** — leaning toward camera before a contrarian truth. Point students to these the first time you watch a Cash video.



Which people, and how do you know?

— CASH

CASH TO COMPANY

Which people, and how do you know?

Cash is the friendly coin who helps us notice, ask, and try again. Cash will be with us all year. — Grade 1